

— THE — KNOWN BEGINNING

BOOK ONE OF THE HEAVENS GATES CHRONICLES



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Book One of the Heavens Gates Chronicles

By Robert Leon Geter II

*A novel of power, inheritance, music, and the first public
naming of a hidden system.*

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*Dedicated to those who came before us with no
ownership but still passed down vision.*

*To those who survived with fragments and left us
enough to build with.*

*And to those coming after us, that they may inherit
structure instead of struggle alone.*

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Chapter One - Of Barry Parker and the Hidden Roads

Most people only know the beginning from the moment a man becomes visible.

They do not count the roads that shaped him before the city learned his name. They do not count the old women who spoke warnings over him in kitchens full of heat and memory. They do not count the houses where prayer and tension sat at the same table and still called each other family. They do not count the miles between one branch of blood and another, nor the way a child can be raised by more than one geography at once. And they surely do not count the quiet instructions a boy absorbs before he ever gains the words to explain the world back to itself.

So when Columbia first began noticing Barry Parker, most people thought they were witnessing his rise.

They were not.

They were witnessing his arrival into view.

Barry Parker was born in Columbia, South Carolina, but Columbia was not the only place that claimed a hand in his becoming. The city gave him the red-clay weight of the South, the soft-spoken caution of old Black households, the codes of respect that let a man be raised by women and judged by men at the same

time. It gave him church memory, family memory, and the kind of restraint that taught a person not to say every thought that came to him simply because it was there.

But the bloodline did not stay in one place.

Some of his people went north in the long wake of the Great Migration, part of that great Black motion that history liked to soften into a story about jobs and escape. Barry would later come to understand that movement more clearly than most. Black people did not simply run toward opportunity. They adapted under pressure. They shifted from one arrangement of power into another. In one place the burden had cotton, caste, and county law on its face. In another it wore factories, city wards, rent traps, industrial fatigue, police zones, and tightly managed neighborhoods. The plantation changed shape. The pressure did not.

His people knew that even when they did not explain it in those exact terms.

One branch planted itself in Inkster, Michigan, close enough to Detroit for the city's rhythm to spill across the line. Another branch stretched southward toward Miami, where another language of Black ambition and survival had already formed. Barry's own line stayed in Columbia, rooted to place, but they moved enough between kin that he grew up understanding something

early: Black life wore different clothes from city to city, but the deeper struggle often walked beneath them all.

That gave him range before he had language.

As a child, Barry was quiet in the way that makes grown folks either underestimate you or watch you harder. He was not soft. He was attentive. He lingered in rooms longer than other boys because he was listening for the thing beneath the thing. A smile did not impress him much. Loudness did not either. He noticed who changed their tone when a man with money entered. He noticed who joked too hard. He noticed who treated women one way in public and another way once doors closed. He noticed the men who moved like they was never fully settled into one role because they had learned to survive by shape-shifting.

That attention would become one of his first great gifts.

Long before he had property, influence, artists, or a company with a name that carried weight, Barry Parker had learned how to study a room without announcing that he was studying it.

And that, in time, made all the difference.

There were older men who affected him deeply without ever becoming his formal teachers. Some carried business in their hands even when they stood

in the dirt. Some carried ruin in their eyes even when they dressed like success. Some had made peace with compromise. Some had not. Some knew exactly how much of themselves they had sold to make it through the last decade and wore that truth with a smile so polished it passed for charm. Barry saw all of it and stored it away.

He did not yet know that one day the city would call him a businessman, a promoter, a builder, a hustler, a visionary, a manipulator, a protector, and a threat all at once.

At that age, he was only learning the oldest lesson first:
A man is rarely what the surface first reports.

That lesson stayed with him.

It stayed with him when family traveled north and south and came back with different accents of the same struggle. It stayed with him when elders spoke in warning codes instead of direct instruction. It stayed with him when church language and street language appeared to oppose each other while secretly explaining the same human frailty from different ends.

And by the time Columbia finally began saying his name with interest, Barry Parker had already been in the making for years.

This, then, is not the true beginning of Barry Parker.

It is the known beginning.

Chapter Two - Of Inkster, Detroit, and the First Stain

When Barry was thirteen, the road north widened something in him.

Inkster was not Detroit, but it lived near enough to feel Detroit breathing on its neck. Fifteen or twenty miles from the west side depending on traffic, mood, and who was driving. Close enough for the city's pace, vice, beauty, and exhaustion to spill outward into smaller streets that still carried big-city hunger in their veins.

His people there were spiritual and devoted to Christ, but they were not naive. They had that particular Black realism that comes from serving God without ever forgetting what this world is capable of. Their homes held Scripture, yes, but also warnings. They knew prayer did not erase consequence. They knew a child still needed sharp eyes even when his household believed in grace.

Barry learned fast up there.

Inkster showed him one kind of life. Detroit showed him another. He would slip toward the city whenever he could, drawn not by childish rebellion alone but by a deeper curiosity. He wanted to see how people moved when there was more pressure, more temptation, more money, more decay, and more speed

all mixed together. He watched hustlers, prostitutes, junkies, pimps, church mothers, old men with game, boys pretending to be men, and men who had already surrendered too much of themselves to ever become whole again. He did not judge them in the shallow way children are taught to judge. He studied them.

He studied the angle of a liar's confidence. The limp swagger of a man who thought vice was power. The odd nobility that sometimes appeared in ruined people when they forgot to perform. The way a person's appetite could outrun their discipline and make them a danger to themselves first.

In Detroit's orbit, Barry started seeing life from every aspect of the game.

That sharpened him.

It also stripped him of innocence earlier than it should have.

One summer night, he got mixed up in something he had no business touching. Money. Heroin. Adrenaline. Wrong company. The kind of foolish, crooked opportunity that looks like a shortcut to young minds and like a curse to older ones. He and a boy he thought was a friend had taken part in robbing a dealer. Thirty bundles. Close to fourteen hundred dollars. Too much poison, too much money, too much ego, too much temptation for boys that young.

What Barry remembered most later was not the specifics.

It was the feeling.

The room. The disrespect. The shift in the air when he realized the friend beside him had already decided to lil-boy him and take everything. Barry was smaller. Younger. Easier to dismiss if all a person knew how to measure was height and weight. The other boy thought size was law.

Barry learned otherwise.

His mother had once told him something simple and fierce: **Don't never let anyone take anything away from you.** She had not passed down land. She had not passed down investments. She had passed down survival intelligence refined through generations of Black struggle, theft, pressure, and forced adaptation. It was not clean inheritance. It was old game born from pain.

And in that room, those words rose in him.

What happened next lived in fragments after that. Not because the moment lacked force, but because memory sometimes protects a person from the exact shape of what it knows. Barry remembered dropping his head. Remembered saying, *That's fucked up, dawg*, with just enough defeat in his voice to lower the other boy's caution. Remembered the rusty dull knife his

mother had given him years earlier, the one nobody knew he still carried. Remembered drawing back. Remembered shock. Remembered the sudden collapse of false power.

Then the reel broke.

That was the first stain.

Not because he defended himself. Not only because of the blood. But because he knew, even at thirteen, that divine warning and divine violation had entered the room together. The night had already crossed sacred order before the betrayal even came. He had taken part in wrong before reacting to wrong. That contradiction never fully released him.

Years later, it would still return in dreams.

Money on a table. A face turning from arrogance to disbelief. His mother's words hovering like both command and lament. Then silence. Then waking with the feeling that survival had saved his body while placing a mark somewhere deeper.

When he returned to Columbia, he carried more than memory.

He carried burden.

And burden, if a man lives long enough, either makes him cruel, careless, or deliberate.

Barry Parker became deliberate.

Chapter Three - Of Columbia and the Studying of the Sound

When Barry came back to Columbia, the city looked the same but did not feel the same.

That happens when a person's eyes have changed before the streets do.

The buildings were still the buildings. The clubs were still the clubs. The neighborhood gossip still moved through porches, kitchens, parking lots, family gatherings, and corner stores like it always had. But Barry now understood something he had not fully understood before: a city is not just streets and structures. It is a pattern of who gets to own what, who gets heard, who gets used, who gets buried, and who mistakes surviving for governing.

Columbia had talent.

That much was obvious.

Boys rapped like they were trying to outrun the weight of being born in the wrong decade and the wrong amount of money. Girls sang with gospel residue still in their lungs even when they tried to sound secular. DJs knew how to bend a crowd. Producers were beginning to imagine things bigger than local access. Hustlers with extra cash wanted to attach themselves

to sound because they sensed what music could do for reputation, women, and distance from the block.

But the city had no real protective infrastructure of its own.

Everybody reached for the light. Nobody built the power source.

Barry saw that clearly.

So while the city thought he was just another young man moving through nightlife, local showcases, parking lots, club corridors, and talent circles, Barry was actually studying the board. He watched who had skill and who only had image. Who had discipline and who only had hunger. Who could take instruction. Who needed pressure. Who would sell a future for a short-term shine. Who wanted ownership. Who only wanted to look associated with ownership.

The city called that promoting.

Barry called it reconnaissance.

He learned the shape of rooms. Which club owners were desperate enough to rent to anybody. Which sound systems always seemed to fail because the men around them were lazy. Which local names had genuine pull and which had been inflated by intimidation. Which boys were talented enough to save and wild enough to waste if nobody got to them first.

He studied radio too.

Not just what songs got played, but what kind of gatekeeping breathed behind the playlist. He watched how some sounds got treated as local flavor while others got packaged as commercial possibility the moment outside validation touched them. That told him plenty. It told him local talent did not only need a microphone. It needed a machine. A set of rooms, roles, laws, and loyalties strong enough to keep creation from being instantly consumed by parasites.

That was when the idea first began hardening in him:
not just a label,
but a system.

Not just a studio,
but infrastructure.

Not just songs,
but an ecosystem.

He did not announce that to anyone.

Barry was not the kind of man who emptied his true plans into the air for applause. He let the city misunderstand him for a while because misunderstanding gave him room. Let them think promoter. Let them think local hustle. Let them think club man. Those roles kept doors open without forcing him to show the blueprint too soon.

And Columbia, to be fair, was used to men fronting motion without any actual architecture behind them. That made Barry even easier to misread.

He moved clean. Dressed in black. Sometimes a trace of red. Beard already carrying maturity beyond his years. Speech measured. Steps precise. Warm enough not to alarm ordinary people. Cold enough that sharper ones knew not to test him without a reason. He looked like a man with some game. He was that. But he was more than that.

He was building his eye.

And in time, that eye would recognize the vessels the city itself had not yet learned how to hold.

Chapter Four - Of Slim Mac and the Crooked Door

Every city keeps at least one crooked door alive because too many people are too desperate to stop using it.

In Columbia, one of those doors wore the name Slim Mac.

Slim Mac was the kind of local kingpin who understood just enough about music to exploit it and not enough about culture to steward it. He had money. He had a studio. He had an established local record company by the city's modest standards. He had enough influence in violence-adjacent circles that men lowered their voice around his name. Most dangerous of all, he had learned how to make exploitation look like opportunity.

That made him useful to the wrong people and appealing to the desperate.

Slim loved shine more than sound. He loved being seen as the man behind things. Loved local artists orbiting him. Loved the idea that every promising voice in the city had to pass through his crooked door at some point. He fed off dependency. Fed off the illusion that access itself was a blessing even when the terms were poison.

Barry Parker knew his type immediately.

Barry did not hate crooked men simply because they were crooked. He understood the world too well for naive outrage. What he hated was a particular class of parasite: the kind that drained Black talent while pretending to develop it, weakened whole communities while calling it business, and wrapped vanity in the language of uplift.

Slim Mac was one of those.

So when Slim came needing one of Barry's buildings for a larger event, Barry said yes.

Not because he trusted him.

Because he wanted the whole board in one room.

Slim had attached a few nationally known acts to the flyer, enough to bring out the city's rappers, singers, camera boys, beatmakers, hangers-on, small-time managers, girls with voices, boys with verses, neighborhood hustlers, real talent, fake talent, and everybody hoping to be near the future before it had a proper name. Barry understood what that kind of gathering could reveal.

To outsiders, it looked like business.

To Barry, it was a census of the city's hunger.

He put his own security in place. Top-notch. Clean. Professional. Not the kind of men who made a room

tense just by standing in it. Barry hated unnecessary violence and sloppy force. When people felt safe at his establishments, it was not because danger never came close. It was because he understood that real control often looks like calm from a distance.

He wanted to see the artists in one room. The engineers. The beatmakers. The camera crews. The fake moguls. The neighborhood money. The young talent trying too hard not to look hungry. He wanted to see who watched whom, who deferred to whom, who had actual pull, and who only had a loud entrance.

Most of all, he wanted to see how Slim Mac moved when he thought he was the sun.

Men reveal themselves clearest when they believe the room belongs to them.

That night, the city would come out hoping for discovery.

Barry Parker would come out looking for recognition.

And by the end of it, he would meet the young man who would change the shape of everything that came after.

Chapter Five - Of Lil Gangsta and the Night of Recognition

By the time the crowd thickened, the whole building felt like a body waiting on its pulse.

Slim Mac floated around the venue in his usual fashion, performing ownership more than carrying it. Local artists moved through the room trying to look unfazed by possibility. National names brought the right amount of glamour and distance. Camera crews floated through it all trying to capture whatever later might look like significance. Outside, the parking lot held what parking lots always hold in a city like Columbia: envy, pride, flirtation, unfinished business, and the possibility of disrespect.

Barry watched from several angles over the course of the evening. Never in one place too long. Never loud. Never seeming rushed. He did not need to be the face of the room to govern its breathing.

That was when he noticed the young man they called Lil Gangsta.

Barry had heard the name already. Everybody had. Not because the city had records flooding the region. Not yet. But because Lil Gangsta's name moved through two worlds at once. In one, people spoke on his talent. In the other, they spoke on his reputation.

Those two streams crossing inside one nineteen-year-old always meant something.

He was not some major drug lord. Not yet a fully formed kingpin. But killers and dealers already saluted him as future. He dabbled in robberies, drugs, extortion, and the kind of rumors that follow a young man when his name begins generating more fear than his age should allow. Still, older people in the city liked him. That was the contradiction. He respected elders. He respected women. He kept old law where his generation had started letting too much slip. That made people see him as more than a street boy. It made them wonder what he might become if he lived long enough to choose a structure worthy of his gift.

Barry watched him moving through the venue and thought the same thing in different words:

Too much fire. Not enough forge.

The night leaned.

It did not happen in a dramatic movie fashion. Trouble rarely does. First came a subtle shift in the lot. Then a tightening in the attention of the men standing nearest. Then one of those fatal little moments where male pride, old tension, public disrespect, and youth all decide they want the same air.

Barry moved toward it before the crowd fully understood what it was seeing.

Lil Gangsta stood near the edge of the lot facing an older man who had made the common mistake of trying to lil-boy a young wolf in front of witnesses. The details would later blur into rumor, city memory, and self-serving testimony. What remained true was this: the moment turned fast, two bodies dropped in the confusion, and the music stopped mattering immediately.

Screams broke the air. People scattered. Slim Mac disappeared the way cowards with influence usually do, vanishing just early enough to protect themselves and just late enough to later pretend they had stayed strong through the storm.

Barry did not panic.

That was the difference.

He saw in Lil Gangsta not just danger, not just talent, and not just a problem. He saw burden. He saw a young man one wrong structure away from either being used up by the city or locked away by the same machine that had never given him a righteous path to begin with.

So Barry stepped in.

“Move,” he told him.

And Lil Gangsta, for reasons he himself would not fully understand until later, listened.

This was the first true recognition between them.

Not friendship.

Not mentorship.

Not even trust.

Recognition.

And from that point onward, the known beginning
was no longer Barry's alone.

Chapter Six - Of the Ride, the Silence, and the Hidden Rooms

Barry's security moved the way real systems move: quiet, coordinated, forgettable from the outside, unforgettable from the inside.

Witnesses were handled not with extra blood but with money, pressure, and the common civic instinct toward self-preservation. Barry had long ago learned that most people did not wish to become martyrs to another man's chaos. They wanted an exit, a story they could live with, and enough incentive to keep their mouth aligned with their fear.

Barry grabbed Lil Gangsta and took him inside.

They moved through the back of the building, then through a rear door into a narrow alley squeezed between dark structures the city had stopped really seeing. They passed two buildings and entered through a side door into what looked from outside like an abandoned country cinder-block warehouse. Inside, it opened deeper than expected. Office rooms. Purpose hidden inside neglect. The whole route felt like architecture built for vanishing.

Lil Gangsta registered that immediately.

Barry saw the amazement in him and simply said, "Come on."

At the far back, another door opened into a parking lot connected to a church. As soon as they stepped out, a black 1964 Lincoln Continental rolled up and one of the suicide doors opened. Inside sat Malaika, pecan tan, six thick wicks falling around her shoulders, dark hazel-brown eyes carrying the calm of a woman who had learned not to waste her energy on visible panic.

They got in.

The car drove off as if no violent crime had just punctured the night.

That was not cruelty. That was poise.

Barry moved by a simple law in moments like that: be part of the backdrop, not the performance. Panic makes men sloppy. Sloppy gets men caught or killed. Neutrality in posture lets survival breathe.

He nodded to Malaika. She pulled a bag of herbs and a fresh box of White Owl New Yorkers from the compartment between the seats. Barry rolled one, then another, then another, until all five were done with the same deliberate calm he carried into everything else. He passed the blunts out without speech. Told the driver to hit the country. Nina Simone started playing softly in the background.

They rode toward the Ferry in silence.

More got explained in that silence than actual talking could have done. Lil Gangsta realized that Barry

Parker was not some regular promoter, not some loud local hustler, and not some imitation mogul trying to hold the city by making everybody else dependent on his crumbs. Barry moved with system. With order. With a kind of ownership-driven law that made men like Slim Mac look small even when they had more visible money.

Barry did not question him about the lot.

He did not sermonize.

He did not try to own the boy's fear by naming it before it had even settled.

That mattered.

By dawn, Lil Gangsta understood that Barry was not offering him escape.

He was offering him a different structure.

And that difference would change the city.

Chapter Seven - Of the First Studio and the Law of Building

The building sat off South Beltline, still unfinished, still raw, still carrying more dust than glory. But Barry walked through it like he could already hear the future inside the walls.

He showed Lil Gangsta the rooms, the bones of what was coming, the outbuilding that would later hold video work and visual production. He left a bag of reefer, gave access, and began explaining not just what the space was, but what it meant.

“I’m not building just no studio,” Barry told him. “I’m building infrastructure. A system. A way to take back control and ownership as a whole. A real ecosystem.”

That word hit Gangsta harder than Barry knew.

No one in Columbia was talking like that.

Studios, yes. Labels, yes. Flyers, buzz, songs, yes. But ecosystem? Ownership across the whole chain? The city’s musical spirit returned to itself in coordinated form? That was different.

Gangsta asked how long he had and how much he owed.

Barry told him he owed nothing.

“The ones that gave you that gift tryna talk to you,” Barry said. “That’s who you owe.”

Then Barry laid down the first law that would echo through the rest of Book One:

“If you not building, that means you stagnant. And when you ain’t making no motion, that’s when decay and infection set in.”

He warned him too, without pressing too hard on the previous night.

“When you move,” Barry said, “move with justice on your side. Because when you violate what’s sacred, the price is always more than you willing to pay. It can be paid. But it cost.”

Gangsta heard that part with his spirit, not just his ear.

And with that, the young man the city feared and loved in equal measure was left alone inside the skeleton of a future he had not known was even possible.

Chapter Eight - Of Asad Jones and the Pairing of Spirits

Asad Jones came through the studio the next morning and found an old face in a new room.

He and Lil Gangsta knew each other from Columbia High. Same city. Same age range. Different route. Asad had leaned more toward school, sports, quiet intelligence, and the kind of low-key slickness that never looked street but never looked soft either. Barry had hired him eighteen months earlier after watching him fix a failed soundboard at a family banquet when the paid man on the job could not do it. Barry fired the fool and hired Asad before the banquet was even over.

Now, at nineteen years old, Asad was functioning as chief audio and music engineer inside one of the most quietly legitimate production and promotion systems growing in Columbia.

He trained Gangsta on the equipment faster than expected. Enough to let him build. Enough to let him hear himself differently. Enough to let the room stop being some foreign machine and start becoming an extension of instinct.

Later, when Asad walked into Barry's office to report back, Barry was on the phone closing out another matter. He motioned him inside, told the person on the

line thank you for handling it and that there would be no further occurrences of that magnitude, then hung up and asked the one thing that mattered:

“How he sound?”

Asad answered honestly. Serious. Real serious.

Then he described a track Gangsta had already begun building—one that sampled Nina Simone’s “Ne Me Quitte Pas” low in the back while deep drums carried his voice through it. Asad said for a moment it felt like a ritual. Like order and pain had met and neither one wanted to leave.

Barry was not surprised.

Then he told Asad why the pairing mattered.

“You know how to take raw energy and hear the shape hiding inside it,” Barry said. “You know how to let chaos dance with order without making either one of them lose what they are.”

That was why he paired them.

Not because they were alike.

Because they were not.

One came out the wound.

The other came out the discipline.

And Barry understood systems well enough to know that real ecosystems are not built by multiplying one

kind of man. They are built by putting different spirits in right relation to each other.

That was how he intended to build everything that came next.

Chapter Nine - Of Songs, Splits, and the Questioning of Paper

Months passed.

The music got stronger. The city leaned in. Burned CDs moved through cars, kitchens, barbershops, apartment windows, and trunk systems. Lil Gangsta's buzz widened beyond any one side of town and became city talk. The songs sounded like weather with memory in it. Asad gave them shape without stripping them of spirit. Barry kept placing structure around them. And before long, people started noticing that Gangsta was appearing more and more at Barry's establishments and less and less with Slim Mac's entourage.

That kind of absence talks loud.

Slim felt it.

So did his artists.

Then the contract rumors started.

A few people asked to see their paperwork again and found Slim louder than the files. That always told the truth before the paperwork did. Some artists got nervous. Some got angry. Some got practical and started counting how many years of their future had been signed away for too little room and too much pressure.

Slim had always assumed hunger would keep everybody humble.

He forgot that hunger also sharpens questions.

One of the artists asking hardest was Sarah Rae—tall, dark-skinned, petite, and carrying a voice that did not sound like radio fashion. Slim had overlooked her because she did not sound like what he knew how to sell. She did not glide in imitation of the girls getting national pushes. Her voice came from somewhere older. Somewhere the market could not fully own.

Barry heard the deeper thing in her immediately.

By then Gangsta had already had his own public run-in with Slim at a McDonald's off Two Notch and Beltline, where the older man tried to press him with ownership language and slick threats. That conversation told both of them the same truth from opposite directions: Barry's structure was becoming a real alternative, and men like Slim Mac could feel the threat before the city knew how to name it.

Once artists start questioning power, the whole crooked door begins to shake.

And once the city realizes there is another door entirely, the shaking spreads.

Chapter Ten - Of Makaila, the Web, and the Missing Tape

Makaila Parker rarely announced her intelligence because announcing intelligence is for people who still need witnesses.

She moved in paper, numbers, addresses, company structure, and silent observation. When she saw Slim Mac making too many casual visits to Agent Rick Jefferson in Friarsgate, she opened a folder on him. Then another. Then a web.

She had come out of Eastover, country-soft in her speech and iron-hard underneath. Barry met her years earlier in Detroit and recognized in her an honest con artist's brilliance—a woman who could read financial systems the way some people read weather. He taught her system-building. She sharpened his operation with execution. Together they became a low-key power couple the public could not fully map because they never lived loud enough to give the city a clean picture.

They had separate rhythms, separate houses, a family house where bloodlines gathered, and enough discipline to keep the city guessing. Barry mostly traveled at night. If people saw him in daylight, it was because he was in the middle of business, going to it,

or coming from it. Makaila stayed even less legible to outsiders. That was part of her strength.

When she overheard Slim telling Agent Jefferson where the tape was hidden—under the doghouse in his yard—she acted first and informed Barry second. The tape was retrieved. The contract book was taken too.

The contract book proved as valuable as the tape itself.

Inside it were agreements, side letters, debt structures, exploitative percentages, and enough paper distortion to confirm what artists had already begun feeling in their spirit. Makaila even fed a rumor to the media that Slim Mac's home had been broken into and his contract book stolen. That move made his own roster question him harder while keeping the true line of the strike hidden.

When Barry praised Makaila for how clean and thorough she had moved, it did not sound like romance in the soft sense.

It sounded like recognition.

They were each other's backbone that way.

By the time the state reached for the evidence it thought would seal Lil Gangsta's fate, the center of the narrative was already gone.

That was the first time the people trying to bury Leon Moyd felt real uncertainty.

Chapter Eleven - Of the Arrest, the Holding Cell, and the Keeping of Nerve

Months after the shooting, the law finally moved in public.

Unmarked cars hit Greene. County and narcotics men jumped out. Leon Moyd was arrested and humiliated for the cameras in connection with the downtown murder outside Barry Parker's event center. They also caught a gun on him. Not the gun from the case. But that was not known yet.

The city watched two narratives get pushed at once.

Young violent rapper.

Street principal finally caught.

The state loved that kind of split-screen story because it did the work of imagination for them.

In the holding cell and interrogation room they ran the usual routine: screaming, threats, pressure, then good cop and bad cop. They tried to knock him out his rhythm. Tried to use the city's love for him against him. Tried to make Barry Parker sound absent and powerless.

Gangsta held.

He had doubt, yes. Weight, yes. They had caught him carrying, and he himself had a moment where he wondered if they thought they had him red-handed on everything. But he did not break.

Then the lawyer walked in.

That ended the interrogation.

Outside the room, the tape was requested.

It was missing.

That changed everything.

Gangsta later bonded out on the gun charge, and Lakita, his street sister, came to pick him up. She took him to the house, reminded him that he was starting to learn the difference between motion and sloppiness, and left him with that truth.

Meanwhile Barry and Makaila quietly began fighting to turn the gun matter into probation and strip the state of the public posture it had built around his arrest. They worked through lawyers, pressure, paper, relationships, timing, and the kind of behind-the-scenes structure most people mistake for luck when it finally pays off.

Barry did not flood Gangsta with details.

He only sent the message that mattered:

Hold your own. Ride it out. Let them humiliate themselves. Then come back vindicated.

Chapter Twelve - Of Sarah Rae, the Spell, and the Gathering of the Sound

Sarah Rae came through the studio while Gangsta was in session. Asad walked her in. Gangsta was genuinely glad to see her and told her to get straight in the booth.

By then, he had learned the studio so well that Asad was freed to keep the rest of the building moving. Barry had taught both of them hands-on how to build and coordinate. In many sessions Gangsta was functioning almost like the head engineer himself. He knew enough about flow, boards, arrangement, timing, and the room's inner logic that the place no longer intimidated him. It answered him.

That day he pulled up Nina Simone's "I Put a Spell on You." Not the whole thing, not in a lazy flip, but enough of the old dark ache to call a spirit into the room. Sarah Rae stepped into it and sang like the streets had become a woman and finally decided to tell the truth.

The hook made the whole concept clear:

The streets as seduction. The streets as vow. The streets as possession.

"I put a spell on you because you're mine."

Gangsta's verses turned the song into confession. He was fighting to leave the streets while still feeling their hand around his spirit. Sarah Rae personified what he was trying to escape.

When Barry heard it while passing the room, he stopped and listened. Gangsta waved him in. Barry called Makaila to come witness it. By the time she arrived, the track had settled into one of those rare forms where symbolism and feeling marry each other so clean that nobody in the room needs the meaning explained.

Slim Mac had once had both of these artists on his roster.

And lost both.

Not because he lacked money.

Because he lacked reverence.

This session was more than a song. It was proof. The beginning of the music concept made audible.

Different faces of Columbia's spirit gathered into one body of sound.

And in that room, Barry saw the future stop being theory.

Chapter Thirteen - Of Label Wars, Foreign Patterns, and the Watching of Barry Parker

The success had side effects.

Slim's artists started splitting. Some formed their own studio setups. Some stayed loyal out of fear, debt, habit, or ambition. Soon there were small label wars across the city—allegiance, sabotage, local violence, bruised ego, and old street tensions all attaching themselves to the shifting music board.

Barry did not celebrate that. It was a side effect no one fully expected, and it told him that any new structure built in Black cultural space would immediately draw both hope and predation.

There were followers still loyal to Slim, still trying to create trouble, still hoping to make Barry's rise look like chaos instead of design. Fights broke out around shows. Rumors circulated. Small-time men tried to convert cultural movement back into street leverage. The same parasite reflex kept showing itself under different clothes.

At the same time, Barry started noticing something overseas. A subgenre of rap gaining traction in London and parts of Africa where gangs were openly warring in songs, turning street conflict into musical brand.

Drill. The sound itself was not his first concern. The pattern was. The culture around it was. When he saw major-label money beginning to invest in it, including men like Paul Slimeberg, Barry knew enough to recognize a scheme even if he did not yet hold every piece.

Violence was being formatted.

Destruction was being distributed.

Black death and retaliation were once again being positioned as product.

Barry began a dossier.

Quietly. Methodically. Without speeches.

He understood something deeper than most music men ever do:

The war over sound is always also a war over what a people are being trained to glorify.

That realization did not stop him.

It refined him.

If the machine had already prepared countermeasures for Black self-owned cultural growth, then Barry would need to redesign faster, build smarter, and make sure Heavens Gates did not become just another doorway for destruction under a cleaner name.

That was the work now.

Not just expansion.

Discernment.

Chapter Fourteen - Of Declaration

The function was packed before it officially began.

Artists, singers, producers, engineers, camera boys, club owners, neighborhood observers, old hustlers, church women trying to understand what exactly they were hearing, and younger dreamers hoping they were standing near history—all of them gathered under one roof while the city felt itself leaning toward something it could not yet fully name.

By then, the spell song had already started moving through Columbia. Lil Gangsta's records had begun carrying more than buzz. Sarah Rae had become proof that ancestral voice still had a place in the future. Asad was helping hold rooms and systems together. Makaila was holding the paper side with the precision of a hidden accountant-general. Slim Mac's world was fraying. The city was splitting into camps. Violence circled. Hope circled too.

Barry Parker stood before the crowd with his usual measured calm.

He did not speak like a man unveiling a gimmick.

He spoke like a man naming what had already been built in silence.

He made it plain that this was not just another label. Not a vanity imprint. Not one man's ego project. What

he was declaring was an independent confederation of artists, engineers, producers, and emerging labels working in interdependence, each keeping one hundred percent ownership of what they created, each building with and through a larger system rather than beneath an exploiter.

He named budgets according to proof, discipline, labor, and talent. He named ownership as law. He named infrastructure as necessity. He named collaboration without surrender. He named self-governed cultural power as the future.

He did not beg the city to believe him.

He gave the city something heavier than invitation.

A standard.

A challenge.

A declaration.

Then, before the city, Barry Parker finally gave the hidden structure its public name.

Heavens Gates Music Group.

The room changed when he said it.

Some heard a promoter.

Some heard a hustler with ambition.

Some heard a threat.

Some heard the ending of one order and the beginning of another.

The wise heard a builder of systems.

And on that night, the city learned that Barry Parker had not merely been moving through music.

He had been preparing a state.

Thus ended **The Known Beginning**, being Book One of the Heavens Gates Chronicles.